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He fled from his village on the Punjab-Sindh border with his two children. It took him a year to get the requisite papers to cross over to India. His wife Samda was abducted by a group of religious preachers and forced to convert to Islam. A local Urdu newspaper carried a picture of the event, praising the Wahhabi preachers.



moved to India and settled in the Bikaner district. On his arrival in Jodhpur, Arjunram went to visit his daughter, violating the law which prohibits such migrants from leaving their assigned district till they get permanent citizenship. The police arrested him along with his son two months ago and they are still in jail. Says Gumanaram's wife Laxmi: "We freed ourselves from one trap only to walk into another. Why can't we visit our relatives and ancestral villages when we belong to this country?" Similarly, Miraba Rathore, 42, a Rajput widow, was jailed for 25 days for leaving Rajkot district to visit her relatives in Kutch. Says Miraba: "We never imagined that we would be persecuted in this manner in India."

Kabiraram, 60, and wife Rani, are the latest to join the stream of migrants to Jodhpur. The couple, who landed last fortnight, is distraught as despite several attempts, they were not given visas for their six children. The Indian High Commission is extremely discouraging in issuing visas to even these persecuted Hindus as part of its Pakistan policy. Trapped between the Wahhabis and Indian se-

curity agencies who treat anyone from Pakistan as potential terrorists, they are nowhere people. In Pakistan, they are reviled as idol worshippers even though many have Muslim names and wear salwar-kameez to avoid being singled out.

Karim Bhil, 24, recalls the constant pestering by Tablighi preachers who would come to their village and say: "If you convert to Islam and stop worshipping these stone idols you will go to paradise." Says Karim: "With each passing day, it was becoming more and more difficult to live with a Hindu identity in Pakistan, even with Muslim names." Adds Laxman Meghwal, who has recently migrated with his family of six to Jodhpur: "The Wahhabis, for the past two years, are not allowing Hindus to celebrate the famous festival of Ramdevpir near Hyderabad that was being observed since hundreds of years."

That also points to the other leg of the trauma triangle. Apart from persecution in Pakistan and harassment in India, a third feature of this heart-rending story is about

broken families. Almost all the migrants have large number of relatives back in Pakistan who want to move to India but can only come on a one-month visa and then apply to the state Government for extensions, stating religious persecution. The state Government is permitted to extend the stay for six months after which the powers to grant permanent residence or citizenship rest with the Union Home Ministry. That is only granted after a continuous stay of seven years in India.

There are nearly 3.5 lakh Pakistani Hindu migrants now in India, mostly living in Rajasthan and Gujarat. Says Sodha: "There should a clear-cut rehabilitation policy for these refugees which is lacking right now." The Gujarat administration doesn't have a structure to look into their problems and there is also corruption in getting permanent citizenships with collectors having the power to grant citizenship. Rajasthan has formed a local committee to look into the refugee problem but the fact that most are extremely poor and uneducated means that their fate remains uncertain. Sixty-two-years after the Partition, the tragedy continues. ■